IELTS LISTENING

Spelling Words

416 words from three official IDP IELTS articles, sorted so you can learn them

> In Listening, a misspelled answer is **marked wrong**, even if you heard it correctly.

A	**IELTS common spelling mistakes** IDP, 18 May 2023 · ielts.idp.com/prepare/article-ielts-common-spelling-mistakes
B	**IELTS Listening difficult words** IDP, 19 Jan 2022 · ielts.idp.com/prepare/article-ielts-listening-difficult-words
C	**IELTS Listening test: tips to build your vocabulary** IDP, 2020 · updated 10 Jun 2026 · ielts.idp.com/prepare/article-common-vocabulary-ielts-listening

How to learn (IDP's method)

1. **Say** the word
2. **Write** it from memory
3. **Check** it against the book
4. **Repeat** until it is right every time

Go back over your hard words **every week**.

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red letters = the trap: look hard at these ~~crossed out~~ = a wrong spelling IDP shows

AB = the IDP articles that list the word

1 Learn These First

Start here. IDP either names these words as common mistakes or repeats them across its articles.

Words IDP names as common mistakes

Word	What IDP says
We**d**nesday	commonly misspelled
Feb**r**uary	the first r is often forgotten
autum**n**	the final n is often forgotten
co**mm**uter	often confused with computer
soc**ie**ty	one of the most commonly misspelled words in IELTS
gover**n**ment	one of the most commonly misspelled words in the test
di**ff**erent	one of the most commonly misspelled words in the test
nuclear	often written as unclear

Words that appear in two or three of the IDP articles

IDP repeats these words across its articles, so learn them first.

- ☐ absen**c**e AB
- ☐ a**ss**e**ss** AC
- ☐ aven**ue** BC
- ☐ b**eau**tiful BC
- ☐ begi**nn**ing AB
- ☐ bel**ie**ve BC
- ☐ benefi**c**ial AB
- ☐ boring BC
- ☐ con**sc**ious AB
- ☐ di**ff**i**c**ult BC
- ☐ environment AB
- ☐ e**xc**ite AB
- ☐ e**xc**iting BC
- ☐ for**ei**gn AB
- ☐ influen**t**ial AB
- ☐ li**br**ary BC
- ☐ maint**e**nance AB
- ☐ ne**c**e**ss**ary ABC
- ☐ o**pp**ortunity BC
- ☐ perc**e**ntage BC
- ☐ rh**y**thm AB
- ☐ **sc**ience AC
- ☐ temp**o**rary BC

2 The 7 Spelling Traps

From IDP's article *IELTS common spelling mistakes*, with the wrong spellings from *IELTS Listening difficult words*.

Trap 1 Single and double consonants

Mistakes happen when single and double consonants are close together in one word.

Pattern	Words
Single, then double	a**cross** · pro**cess** · re**comm**end · ne**cess**ary
Double, then single	a**pp**a**r**ent · e**x**a**gg**e**r**ate · o**cc**a**s**ion · pa**r**a**ll**el · i**mm**e**d**iate
Two doubles	a**dd**re**ss** · a**sses**s · a**cc**o**mm**odation · po**sses**s · su**cces**s · o**cc**u**rr**ence

Trap 2 Adding -ed, -ing, -er, -est

Sometimes the last consonant doubles when you add an ending.

Base word	With the ending	Don't write
drop	dro**pp**ed · dro**pp**ing	—
big	bi**gg**er · bi**gg**est	—
run	ru**nn**ing · ru**nn**er	—
begin	begi**nn**ing · begi**nn**er	~~begining~~
regret	regre**tt**ed · regre**tt**ing	—
refer	refe**rr**ed	~~refered~~

Pattern to notice: All these words end in *one short vowel + one consonant* (dr**o**p, b**i**g, beg**i**n). That last consonant doubles before -ed / -ing / -er / -est.

Trap 3 The word changes form

The spelling can change when a word becomes a noun, adjective or verb.

Change	From	To	Don't write
adjective → noun	absent	absen**c**e	—
adjective → noun	different	differen**c**e	—
noun → adjective	benefit	benefi**c**ial	~~benefitial~~
noun → adjective	influence	influen**t**ial	~~influencial~~
noun → adjective	circumstance	circumstan**t**ial	~~circumstancial~~
verb → noun	maintain	maint**e**nance	~~maintainance~~
verb → noun	pronounce	pron**u**nciation	—
noun → verb	excess	ex**ceed**	—
noun → verb	success	su**cceed**	—

Trap 4 Silent letters in consonant groups

You don't hear these letters clearly, so they are easy to leave out.

Letters	Words	Don't write
nm	enviro**n**ment · gover**n**ment	~~enviroment~~
mn	autum**n** · colum**n**	—
sc	con**sc**ious · di**sc**ipline · **sc**ience	~~concious~~
xc	e**xc**ited · e**xc**eption · e**xc**ite	~~exite~~
kn	**k**now · **k**nee · **k**nob	—
th (ordinals)	eigh**th** · twel**f**th	—
g (not j)	privile**g**e	~~privilje~~

Trap 5 Words that sound alike

They sound the same (or nearly the same) but mean different things.

Words	How to tell them apart
lose / loose	**lose** = not win, can't find · **loose** = not tight
affect / effect	**affect** = verb (to change something) · **effect** = noun (the result)
complement / compliment	**complement** = goes well with · **compliment** = nice words about someone
its / it's	**its** = belongs to it · **it's** = it is
passed / past	**passed** = verb (she passed the exam) · **past** = time before / go by (walk past)
principal / principle	**principal** = head of a school, main · **principle** = a rule or belief
than / then	**than** = comparing (bigger than) · **then** = time (and then)
their / there / they're	**their** = belongs to them · **there** = place · **they're** = they are
costume / custom	**costume** = special clothes · **custom** = a tradition

Trap 6 Words that are just hard to spell

- ☐ hier**a**rchy
- ☐ entrepren**eu**r
- ☐ defin**i**tely
- ☐ for**ei**gn
- ☐ gr**a**teful
- ☐ persever**a**nce
- ☐ rh**y**thm
- ☐ maint**e**nance

Trap 7 British vs American spelling

Both British and American spellings are accepted. **Pick one and use it every time.** IDP's own lists use British forms such as *colour, theatre, organisation, licence, neighbour*.

3 IDP's Tricky Words List

IDP's own list of commonly misspelled Listening words. Tick a box only after you spell the word correctly from memory.

☐ library	☐ environment	☐ restaurant	☐ customer
☐ believe	☐ modern	☐ difficult	☐ controversy
☐ separate	☐ comparison	☐ skiing	☐ business
☐ professor	☐ avenue	☐ nuclear	☐ basically
☐ commitment	☐ conscious	☐ disappear	☐ exciting
☐ boring	☐ rhythm	☐ immediately	☐ necessary
☐ original	☐ realistic	☐ receive	☐ February
☐ tendency	☐ obesity	☐ marriage	☐ solar
☐ fuel	☐ friendly	☐ until	☐ beautiful
☐ highway	☐ percentage	☐ million	☐ thousand
☐ hundred	☐ fluctuate	☐ peak	☐ recover
☐ musician	☐ computer	☐ software	☐ video
☐ murder	☐ topic	☐ temporary	☐ unfortunately
☐ disadvantage	☐ argument	☐ Wednesday	☐ neighbour
☐ foreign	☐ opportunity	☐ because	

IDP tip: Say the word, write it, check it, then repeat. Doing this again and again helps you remember the correct spelling.

Plus IDP's "choose the correct one" words

☐ absence	☐ achieve	☐ colleague	☐ deliberate
☐ attack	☐ language		

Watch out: until has one **l** (not *untill*). **argument** drops the **e** of argue. **skiing** has two **i**'s.

4 Part 1 Words

Everyday conversation: forms, bookings, personal details.

Days of the week

☐ Sunday	☐ Monday	☐ Tuesday	☐ Wednesday
☐ Thursday	☐ Friday	☐ Saturday	

IDP tip: Wednesday is commonly misspelled.

Months and seasons

☐ January	☐ February	☐ March	☐ April
☐ May	☐ June	☐ July	☐ August
☐ September	☐ October	☐ November	☐ December
☐ winter	☐ spring	☐ autumn	☐ summer

IDP tip: The first **r** in **February** is often forgotten. The final **n** in **autumn** is often forgotten because you don't hear it. You can write dates in numbers, e.g. 10th February 2020 = 10/02/2020.

Shapes

☐ circle	☐ square	☐ rectangle	☐ triangle
☐ cylinder	☐ oval		

IDP tip: Shapes appear in place names (e.g. *King George Square*), so spell the common ones correctly.

Transport

☐ automobile	☐ truck	☐ tractor	☐ tram
☐ subway	☐ airplane	☐ train	☐ bicycle
☐ car	☐ pedestrian	☐ passenger	☐ commuter

IDP tip: commuter is often misspelled because people confuse it with *computer*.

Colours

☐ red	☐ orange	☐ yellow	☐ green
☐ blue	☐ purple	☐ white	☐ black
☐ brown			

IDP tip: colour is British spelling and **color** is American. Both are correct.

Verbs

☐ suggest	☐ develop	☐ borrow	☐ persuade
☐ discuss	☐ review	☐ concentrate	☐ believe
☐ crash			

IDP tip: Verbs can change form (tense etc.). Writing the wrong form can make your answer wrong.

Adjectives

- ☐ b**eau**tiful
- ☐ ne**c**e**ss**ary
- ☐ fantastic
- ☐ comfortable
- ☐ conven**ie**nt
- ☐ wonderfu**l**
- ☐ te**rr**ible
- ☐ temp**o**rary
- ☐ permane**n**t
- ☐ **k**nowledg**e**able
- ☐ e**xc**iting
- ☐ boring
- ☐ di**ff**i**c**ult
- ☐ easy

IDP tip: Look carefully at adjectives with double consonants (ss / mm). It is easy to miss a letter.

Numbers, times and money

You hear	Write
thirty dollars	$30
six o'clock	6:00
ten thousand	10,000
10th February 2020	10/02/2020

IDP tip: To hear the difference between 13 and 30, listen for the stress: thir-**TEEN** vs **THIR**-ty. Use the same currency symbol as the question. Writing **$** when it should be **£** is wrong.

5 Part 2 Words

A talk about a place: buildings, maps and directions.

Rooms in buildings

- ☐ kitchen
- ☐ bathroom
- ☐ bedroom
- ☐ living room
- ☐ dining room
- ☐ lounge
- ☐ library
- ☐ gymnasium (gym)
- ☐ cafeteria (cafe)
- ☐ classroom
- ☐ waiting room
- ☐ reception
- ☐ ticket desk
- ☐ storage room
- ☐ theatre

Place markers (street names)

- ☐ street
- ☐ road
- ☐ avenue
- ☐ lane
- ☐ drive
- ☐ court
- ☐ place
- ☐ terrace
- ☐ way

IDP tip: On a map question, you will hear some of these words but may not need to write them.

Directions and places

- ☐ north
- ☐ south
- ☐ east
- ☐ west
- ☐ up
- ☐ down
- ☐ right
- ☐ left
- ☐ straight
- ☐ across from
- ☐ between
- ☐ beside
- ☐ diagonal
- ☐ corner
- ☐ opposite
- ☐ adjacent to
- ☐ near
- ☐ past
- ☐ before
- ☐ after

Direction verbs

- ☐ turn
- ☐ move
- ☐ continue on
- ☐ walk
- ☐ cross
- ☐ pass
- ☐ start
- ☐ finish
- ☐ end
- ☐ stop
- ☐ go straight ahead

Places on a map

- ☐ tennis court
- ☐ river
- ☐ courtyard
- ☐ laboratory
- ☐ building
- ☐ bridge
- ☐ road
- ☐ path
- ☐ traffic lights
- ☐ bench
- ☐ seat
- ☐ table
- ☐ basketball court
- ☐ running track
- ☐ swimming pool
- ☐ beach
- ☐ forest
- ☐ garden
- ☐ castle

IDP tip: Write **L** and **R** on the edges of your question paper. If the map has no compass, draw one.

6 Part 3 Words

Students and tutors talking about study.

Study words

☐ presentation	☐ project	☐ teamwork	☐ pairs
☐ organisation	☐ outline	☐ proofreading	☐ experiment
☐ reference	☐ lecture	☐ tutor	☐ teacher
☐ attendance	☐ specialist	☐ knowledge	☐ faculty
☐ bachelor's	☐ master's	☐ schedule	☐ management
☐ leadership	☐ questionnaire	☐ statistic	☐ percentage
☐ laboratory	☐ school	☐ university	☐ college

IDP tip: North Americans say **laboratory** in three syllables (LAB-ruh-tory). British speakers say it in four (la-BOR-a-tory). The spelling is the same.

School subjects

☐ Mathematics (Maths)	☐ Science	☐ English	☐ Physical Education (PE)
☐ Art	☐ Music	☐ Geography	☐ Biology
☐ Chemistry	☐ History		

IDP tip: A school year is divided into **terms** or **semesters**, with holidays between them.

University subjects

☐ Commerce	☐ Science	☐ Psychology	☐ Engineering
☐ Marketing	☐ Sociology	☐ Medicine	☐ History
☐ Geography	☐ Architecture	☐ Law	☐ Philosophy
☐ Economics	☐ Education		

IDP tip: A university year is divided into **semesters**, with exams at the end of each one. Study can be **part-time** or **full-time**.

Exams

☐ assessment	☐ test	☐ revision	☐ pass
☐ fail	☐ repeat	☐ supervise	☐ supervisor
☐ assess	☐ exam	☐ results	☐ degree
☐ certificate			

7 Part 4 Words

A university lecture on an academic topic.

Health

- ☐ vegetarian
- ☐ vegan
- ☐ healthy
- ☐ unhealthy
- ☐ leisure
- ☐ disease
- ☐ vitamin
- ☐ protein
- ☐ carbohydrates
- ☐ exercise
- ☐ treatment
- ☐ obese
- ☐ overweight
- ☐ fit
- ☐ doctor
- ☐ check up
- ☐ medicine
- ☐ pandemic
- ☐ virus
- ☐ cure
- ☐ vaccination

Animals and habitats

- ☐ mammals
- ☐ reptile
- ☐ primates
- ☐ predators
- ☐ prey
- ☐ mountain
- ☐ jungle
- ☐ forest
- ☐ island
- ☐ pond
- ☐ river
- ☐ stream
- ☐ zoo
- ☐ pet
- ☐ endangered
- ☐ species
- ☐ ocean
- ☐ sea

Your own mistake: On 5 Nov you wrote ~~mamals~~. It needs two m's: **mammals**.

Continents and countries

- ☐ North America
- ☐ South America
- ☐ Asia
- ☐ Africa
- ☐ Europe
- ☐ Antarctica
- ☐ Australia
- ☐ Oceania
- ☐ England
- ☐ Canada
- ☐ China
- ☐ United Kingdom
- ☐ Germany
- ☐ Mexico
- ☐ Switzerland

Environment

- ☐ global warming
- ☐ disaster
- ☐ earthquake
- ☐ tornado
- ☐ blizzard
- ☐ hurricane
- ☐ pollution
- ☐ temperature
- ☐ drought
- ☐ flood
- ☐ cyclone
- ☐ volcanic eruption
- ☐ deforestation
- ☐ desertification
- ☐ bush fires

Government

- ☐ politics
- ☐ leader
- ☐ politician
- ☐ senator
- ☐ mayor
- ☐ laws
- ☐ regulations
- ☐ senate
- ☐ president
- ☐ society
- ☐ individual
- ☐ council
- ☐ rules

IDP tip: society is one of the most commonly misspelled words in the IELTS test.

Energy

☐ nuclear	☐ oil	☐ coal	☐ hydro electrical power
☐ natural gas	☐ solar power	☐ source	☐ generate
☐ electricity	☐ dam	☐ windmill	☐ wind turbine
☐ renewable	☐ non-renewable		

IDP tip: Check **nuclear** carefully. People often write ~~unclear~~ by mistake, and that answer is wrong.

General

☐ appointment	☐ cooperation	☐ employment	☐ government
☐ exhibition	☐ occupation	☐ aluminium / aluminum	☐ century
☐ decade	☐ millennium	☐ individual	☐ creativity
☐ guarantee	☐ satellite	☐ opportunity	☐ licence
☐ frequently	☐ calendar	☐ different	

IDP tip: government and **different** are among the most commonly misspelled words in the test. IDP uses the American spelling *aluminum*; the British spelling is *aluminium*. Both are accepted.

8 Test Yourself

Test 1 · Choose the correct spelling

Circle A or B. Every wrong spelling here is one that IDP shows.

1. Ⓐ deliberate	Ⓑ deliberete	9. Ⓐ enviroment	Ⓑ environment
2. Ⓐ privilege	Ⓑ privilje	10. Ⓐ circumstancial	Ⓑ circumstantial
3. Ⓐ influencial	Ⓑ influential	11. Ⓐ achieve	Ⓑ acheeve
4. Ⓐ maintainance	Ⓑ maintenance	12. Ⓐ absense	Ⓑ absence
5. Ⓐ exite	Ⓑ excite	13. Ⓐ concious	Ⓑ conscious
6. Ⓐ beginning	Ⓑ begining	14. Ⓐ benefitial	Ⓑ beneficial
7. Ⓐ atack	Ⓑ attack	15. Ⓐ colleage	Ⓑ colleague
8. Ⓐ langauge	Ⓑ language	16. Ⓐ referred	Ⓑ refered

Test 2 · Dictation sheet

Choose one section of this book. Someone reads the words aloud (or ask Claude to read them with text-to-speech) while you write. Then check against the list. Add every word you get wrong to **section 8 of your Spelling Fix List** and test it again next week.

#	I wrote	✓/✗	#	I wrote	✓/✗
1			16		
2			17		
3			18		
4			19		
5			20		
6			21		
7			22		
8			23		
9			24		
10			25		
11			26		
12			27		
13			28		
14			29		
15			30		

Answers to Test 1: 1 A · 2 A · 3 B · 4 B · 5 B · 6 A · 7 B · 8 B · 9 B · 10 B · 11 A · 12 B · 13 B · 14 B · 15 B · 16 A